Flagpost

USER GUIDE

Competitor Guide

Everything you need to play a CTF on Flagpost

For **Competitors** · Flagpost **1.7.1-src** · 18 October 2026

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CHAPTER 1

Getting started

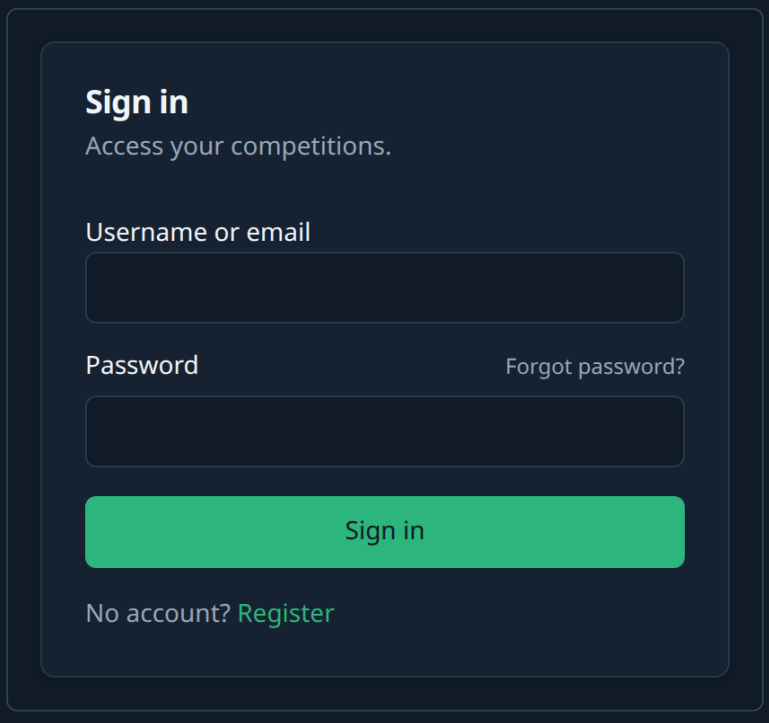
Flagpost is the platform your organisers use to run their capture-the-flag: it hosts the challenges, grades your flags and your code, runs the scoreboard, and connects you with the event staff. Each chapter stands on its own when you need it mid-event — and the guide is always one click away in the app, under **User guides** in the top bar.

Your account

Your **username is your identity**: it's what you sign in with and what the scoreboard shows. An email address is optional unless your organisers require one — adding it is what lets you reset a forgotten password.

Accounts arrive one of three ways: **register yourself** (if public registration is open — some sites limit it to certain email domains), **sign in with an identity provider** (a **Sign in with …** button — Google, Microsoft, GitHub, Discord or your organisation's SSO; the account is created on first use), or **receive credentials** from the organisers. A directory (LDAP) account signs in through the normal username and password form.

Signing in



Sign in with your username or email — or any identity-provider button your site offers.

Forgotten password? **Forgot password?** on the sign-in page emails a reset link — provided your account has an email address.

> **EMAIL VERIFICATION**
>
> Some sites require a verified email before you can **join** a competition. Signing in still works; a blocked join sends you to your Profile, where **Resend verification email** gets you a fresh link.

Your profile

Click your name at the bottom of the sidebar to open **Profile**:

- **Account** — your **profile picture** (PNG, JPEG or WebP), **username** (if your site allows self-service renames: once every 30 days, confirmed with your password), **password**, **email**, and any **registration details** an event asked for.
- **Notifications** — what reaches your bell, desktop notifications, sound (chapter 7).
- **Skills** — the categories you've solved in, across every event on this site.
- **API tokens** — for scripts that talk to Flagpost directly (chapter 8).
- **Certificates** — participation certificates organisers release.

The top bar holds **Language** (English, French, Spanish or Polish, remembered by this browser) and **Theme** (a dark or light palette, or **Use site default**).

> **ONE ACCOUNT, MANY EVENTS**
>
> Your account belongs to the site, not to one competition. The next event on the same instance just needs you to join it — chapter 2.

CHAPTER 2

Joining a competition

A Flagpost site can host many competitions, each with its own challenges, scoreboard and teams. The selector in the top bar switches between the ones you've joined.

Finding your competition

Most organisers send an **invite link.** Open it and you'll see You're invited to …; sign in or **Create an account** if you need to, and you're brought straight back to a one-click **Join competition.** An expired or revoked link just says This link isn't available; if the event has ended or its registration window isn't open, the page tells you so.

Until you've joined your first competition you land in the **Lobby** instead: **Public competitions** list a **Join** button, and **Join with an invite code** takes the code your organisers gave you. (This is the competition code — a team's invite code goes on the Participants page, chapter 6.) To join a later event, use its invite link, or open `/lobby` directly.

Some events ask for **a few details** as you join — affiliation, shirt size, dietary needs. Required ones must be filled before **Join** enables; change your answers later under Profile → Account → **Registration details**.

Rules first

Many events make you **accept the rules** before you can play — tick I have read and accept these rules and **Accept** — and again if the organisers change this competition's rules. Some only display them (**Continue**). Read them either way: they're binding for prizes and conduct decisions.

Individual or team mode

MODE	YOU COMPETE AS	SCOREBOARD SHOWS
Individual	yourself	players
Team	a team you create or join	teams

In a team competition nothing prompts you — open **Participants** in the sidebar and either **Create a team** (you become its captain) or **Join a team** with a teammate's invite code. You can't submit anything until you're on a team. Chapter 6 has the details.

> **DIVISIONS**
>
> Some events split entrants into divisions — say, students and professionals. Organisers assign yours; the scoreboard's **Division** filter then ranks you within it, and prizes are typically awarded per division.

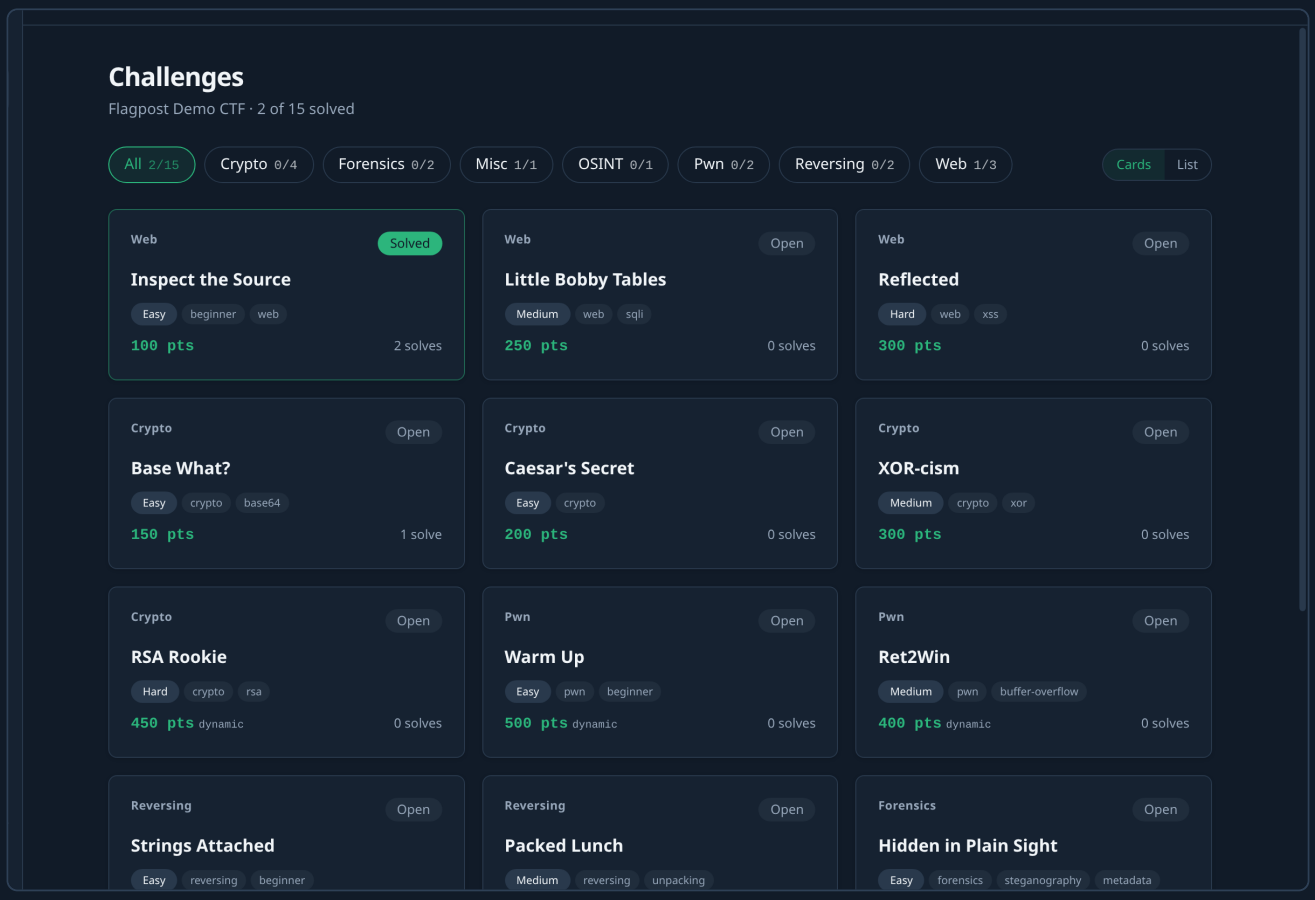
Start and finish

Joining early is normal. Until the organisers **start** the event, the Challenges page shows This competition hasn't started yet — challenges and the scoreboard open the moment it goes live. When the competition **ends**, the Challenges page closes entirely (challenge text, files and notes included), while the scoreboard stays up as **Final standings** and your Dashboard keeps your solves.

CHAPTER 3

Solving challenges

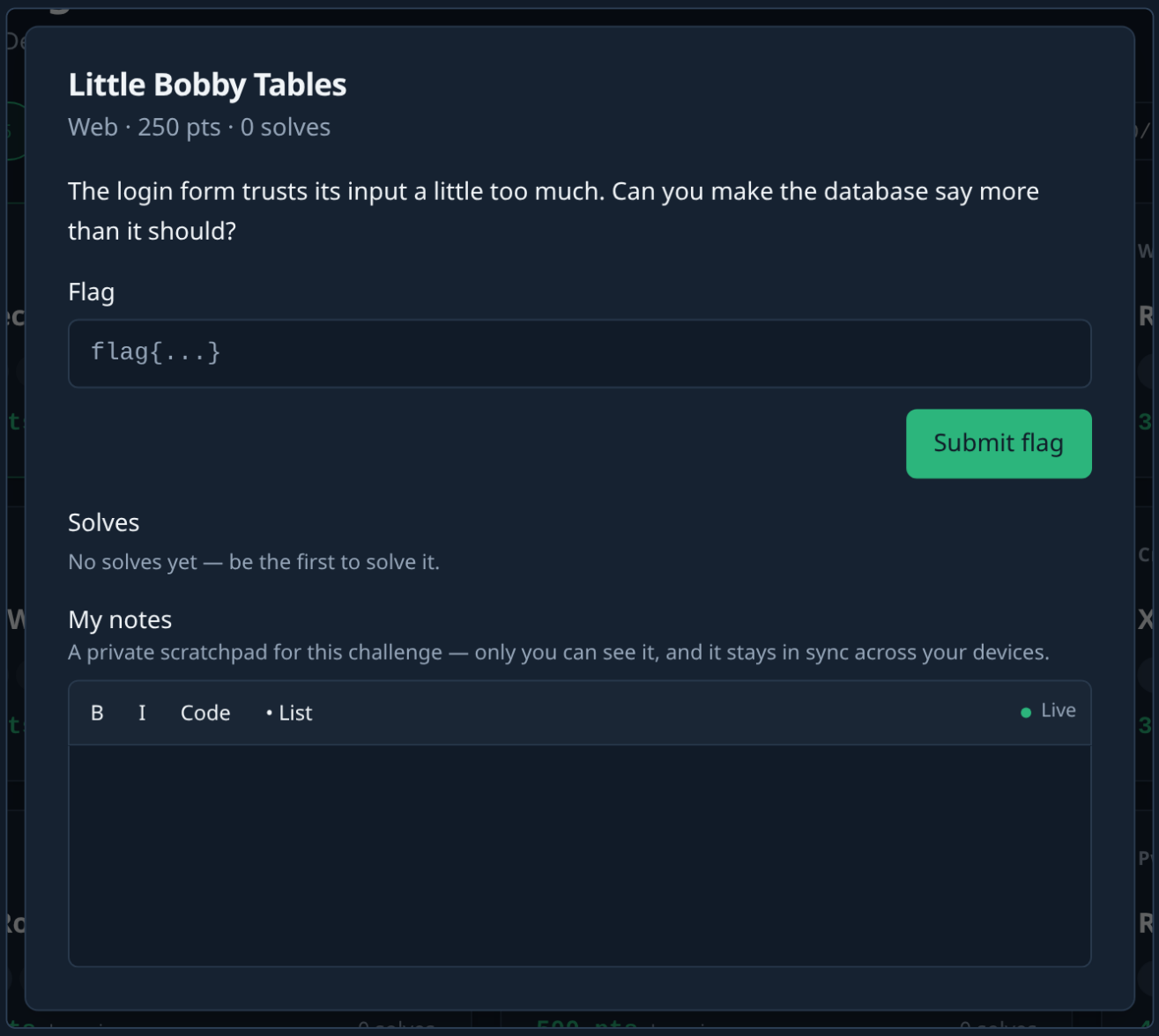
The **Challenges** page is where you'll spend the event.



Category chips filter the board (each with your solved/total); cards carry points, difficulty, tags and a badge: Open, Solved, Locked, or Code. Prefer rows? Switch Cards → List — the choice sticks per device.

Locked means the challenge has prerequisites — solve those first and it unlocks (opening it shows which). **Code** marks a programming challenge, which opens on its own page (chapter 4). New challenges can appear mid-event in waves — watch the announcements.

Inside a challenge



The challenge view: description, flag entry, solves so far, and your notes pad — My notes when you play solo, Team notes in a team event.

Depending on the challenge you'll also see **Files** to download, **Connection** (where the live target runs, with a copy button), **Hints** (chapter 5), **Clarifications from the judges**, and how many others have it open.

Submitting flags

Most challenges want a flag — usually `flag{...}` — pasted exactly as found. Surrounding whitespace is trimmed for you; everything else, including case (unless the authors chose otherwise), must match. A correct flag scores instantly and marks the card solved. Rapid-fire guessing is rate-limited.

Some challenges are **multiple choice** instead:

- Your **guesses may be capped** — the challenge shows how many remain. Out of guesses? Open a support ticket; organisers can reset them.

- Events can enable a **wrong-guess penalty**: each wrong answer lowers what that question is worth to you (or your team) by a stated percentage. The original value shows struck through next to what it's worth now.

Your own instance

Some challenges hand each player or team an **isolated running copy** of a service. In the **Instance** panel, **Launch instance** starts one; once it's running you get the connection details — an `nc host port` line or a clickable link — with a countdown. **Extend** restarts the clock a limited number of times; **Stop** destroys it, and you can launch again. In a team event the instance is shared by the whole team, and launches can be refused when you've hit a cap or are launching too quickly.

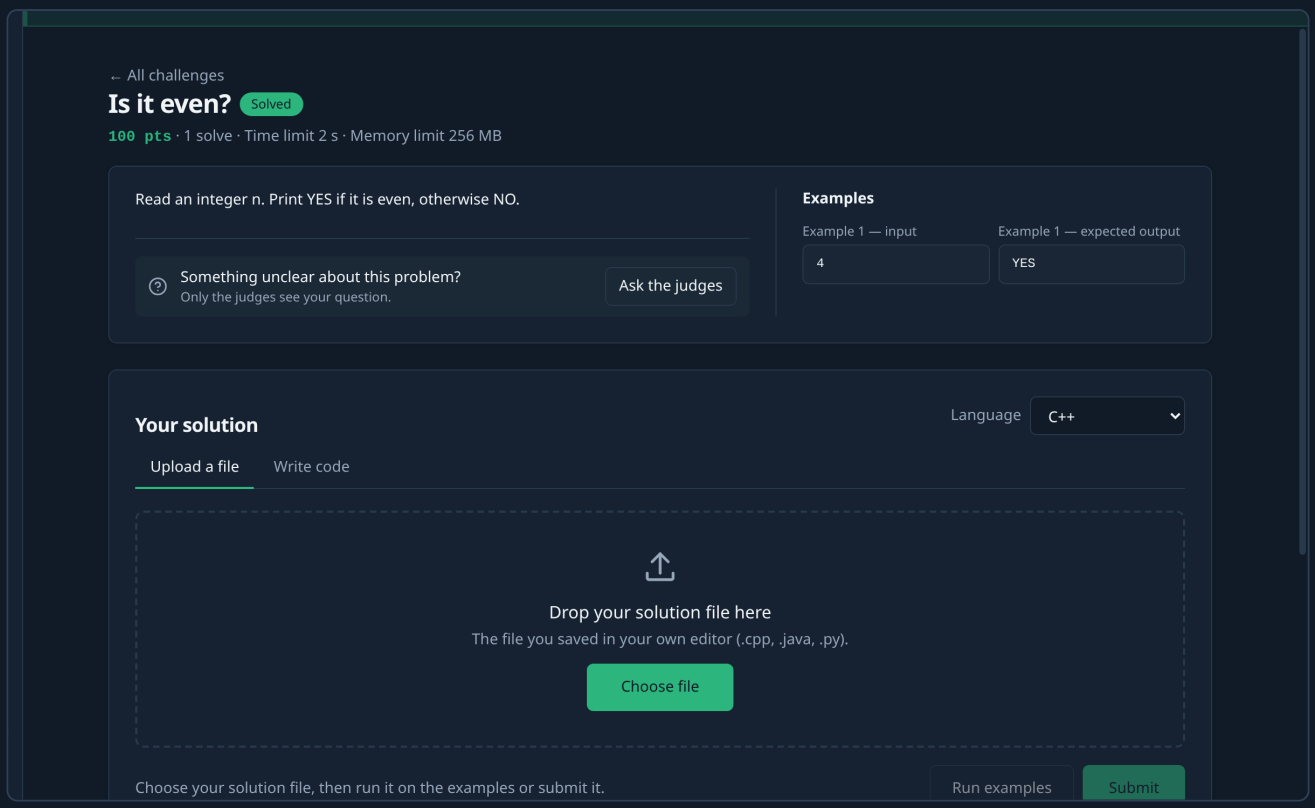
> **UNIQUE FLAGS**
>
> Instanced challenges may give every instance its own flag. It's only accepted while your instance is running (relaunching mints a new one), and submitting another team's flag is recorded as flag sharing.

> **PAUSED COMPETITIONS**
>
> Organisers can pause gameplay during an incident. The Challenges page shows ⏸ The competition is paused, and flag submissions, code submissions and hint reveals close until play resumes.

CHAPTER 4

Programming challenges

Some events include **programming challenges**, solved by submitting a program rather than a flag — the ICPC-style problem: read standard input, print the answer to standard output. They carry a **Code** badge on the board and open on their own page.



The statement with its examples, the limits for your language, and the solution panel.

The problem page

The statement sits beside its **Examples** — each an input and the expected output. The info line gives the **time limit** and **memory limit**; the time limit depends on the **Language** you pick, since slower languages get a proportionally longer allowance. **Files** holds anything the authors attached.

Writing and submitting

Your solution offers two ways in: **Upload a file** (the default — drop the file you saved in your own editor; the language is detected from its extension) or **Write code** in the browser, where your draft is kept per problem and language on this device.

Then **Run examples** to try your program on the visible examples — never scored — or **Submit** to have it judged against every test, hidden ones included. Code files are limited to 128 KB, and you can have at most three submissions waiting at once.

Verdicts

Results update live: Waiting to be judged — 3 in line, then Judging…, then the verdict.

VERDICT	MEANING
Accepted	Passed every test — it scores like a solved flag.
Wrong answer	Output didn't match on some test.
Time / Memory / Output limit exceeded	Your program used more than the limit allows.
Runtime error	It crashed or exited with an error.
Compilation error	It didn't compile — see **Compiler messages**.
Couldn't be judged	A problem on the platform's side, not yours — never scored; submit again.

A failing example shows its input, the expected output and yours; a failing **hidden test** is named only by its number — its data stays hidden. **Your submissions** lists past runs and submissions, and **Load code** brings one back into the editor.

> **VERDICTS CAN CHANGE**
>
> Judges can **rejudge** a problem (after fixing a test, say) or decide a verdict by hand. The newest verdict counts, so points can be gained or taken back later; such entries are marked Rejudged or Judge's decision.

Asking the judges

Statement unclear? **Ask the judges** sends a private question — one message, answered in **Support** (tagged Question; to follow up, ask a new one). If the answer helps everyone, they may share it as a **clarification**, without your name: it appears on the problem under Clarifications from the judges and arrives as a notification. For flag challenges, ask through a normal support ticket instead (chapter 7).

CHAPTER 5

Hints, scoring & the scoreboard

Hints

A hint is either a **Free hint** or **Costs N pts**. **Reveal** charges immediately — no confirmation — and deducts the cost from your (or your team's) score, so agree before spending. Revealed hints stay visible all event, organisers can release extra ones as the competition unfolds, and hints close while the competition is paused.

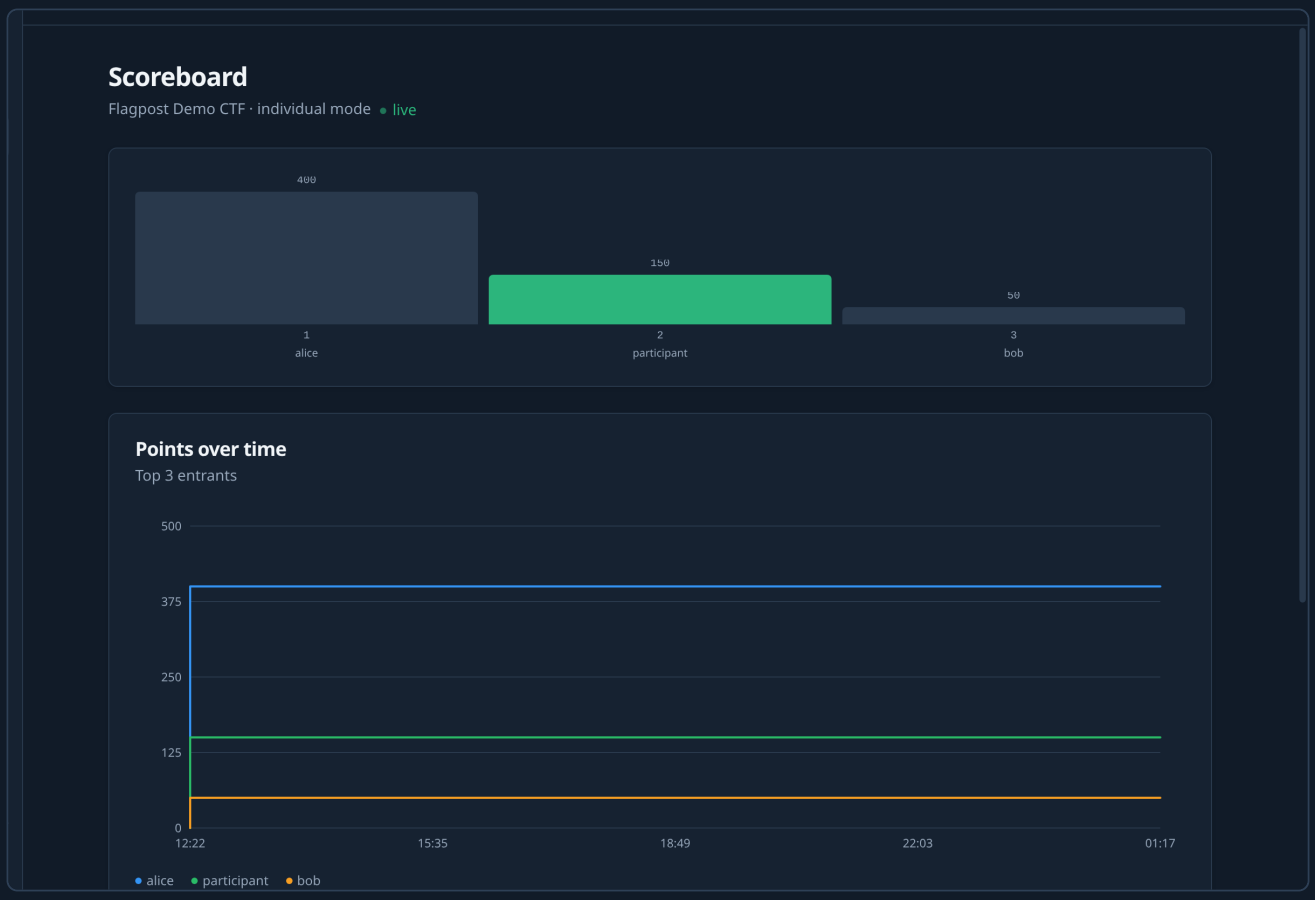
How points work

SCHEME	WHAT IT MEANS FOR YOU
Static	Fixed value — solve any time for the same points.
Dynamic	The value **decays as more people solve it**, from a starting value toward a floor. Every solver holds the current value, first or last.

Dynamic scoring rewards hard challenges naturally: fewer solvers, higher worth — the card always shows the current value. **First blood** — the first solver — is marked on the challenge's solver list; some events attach prizes to it.

Your total is your solve points, minus hint costs, plus or minus any awards or adjustments the organisers make — never below zero. Ties go to whoever made their last solve first.

The scoreboard



Live standings: the top ten as bars and

Points over time for the leaders, with the full table below — your own row is highlighted.

If your event uses divisions, the **Division** filter ranks within one. Some events also publish a **public spectator scoreboard** friends can watch without an account.

> **SCOREBOARD FREEZES**
>
> Many events **freeze** the board near the end to keep the finale suspenseful. You'll see a Frozen badge and The scoreboard is frozen. Solves still count during the freeze — standings, including the scoreboard you see in Flagpost, just stop updating until the organisers unfreeze it. Don't panic when a late solve doesn't appear to move you. For the same reason, a solve during the freeze doesn't tell you whether you took first blood, nor — on a challenge whose value decays — how many points it earned; both would give the hidden standings away.

Rating challenges

If your organisers enable it, How was this challenge? appears after a solve — one to five stars, and you can change your rating later. Authors see aggregate ratings; it genuinely shapes future events.

Certificates

Some events issue participation certificates. When the organisers release them, Your certificate is ready! pops up with a **Download** button, the scoreboard shows a card, and the certificate stays available under Profile → **Certificates** for every event you've earned one in. Organisers choose whether everyone or only scoring participants receive one.

CHAPTER 6

Playing as a team

In team mode your team is the scoring unit: solves, points, hint costs, guess caps and challenge instances are all shared. (Individual players: the notes below work for you too — they're simply private to you.)

Your team

Everything happens on the **Participants** page:

- **Create a team** makes you its **captain**. Tick Require captain approval to join if you want to vet joiners. A team can't be renamed in the app once created, so choose the name carefully — it's what the scoreboard shows at the closing ceremony.
- **Join a team** takes the **Invite code** a teammate shares from your team card. On an approval-required team your request waits for the captain, who sees **Join requests** with Approve / Reject.
- The captain can set the **Team profile** — affiliation, country, website.
- **Leave team** hands captaincy to the longest-standing member; the last member leaving dissolves the team.

Any member's correct flag or accepted program scores for the whole team and shows as solved for everyone — so split the categories and divide the board rather than double-working challenges.

Team notes

Every flag challenge carries **Team notes** — a live collaborative pad, private to your team, separate per challenge. Everyone can type at once, edits merge in real time, and notes persist all event. (Programming challenges have no notes pad.)

Use it as the team's memory: partial progress, working theories, payloads that almost worked. When someone rotates onto a challenge three hours in, the pad tells them everything that's been tried.

Coordinating in practice

1. **Claim loudly** — put "I'm on this" at the top of the pad so two people don't burn the same hour.
2. **Dump progress as you go** — commands, endpoints, credentials, dead ends.
3. **Rotate stuck challenges** — fresh eyes beat tired ones; the pad makes hand-offs cheap.
4. **Watch the value** — on dynamic scoring, sometimes the winning move is to bank easier points first.
5. **One instance per challenge** — the team shares it; agree who launches, extends and stops.

CHAPTER 7

Staying informed & getting help

Your dashboard

Dashboard is where you land after signing in: **Your standing** (rank, points, solved), **Your solves**, and the **Announcements** archive, newest first — glance at it after any break.

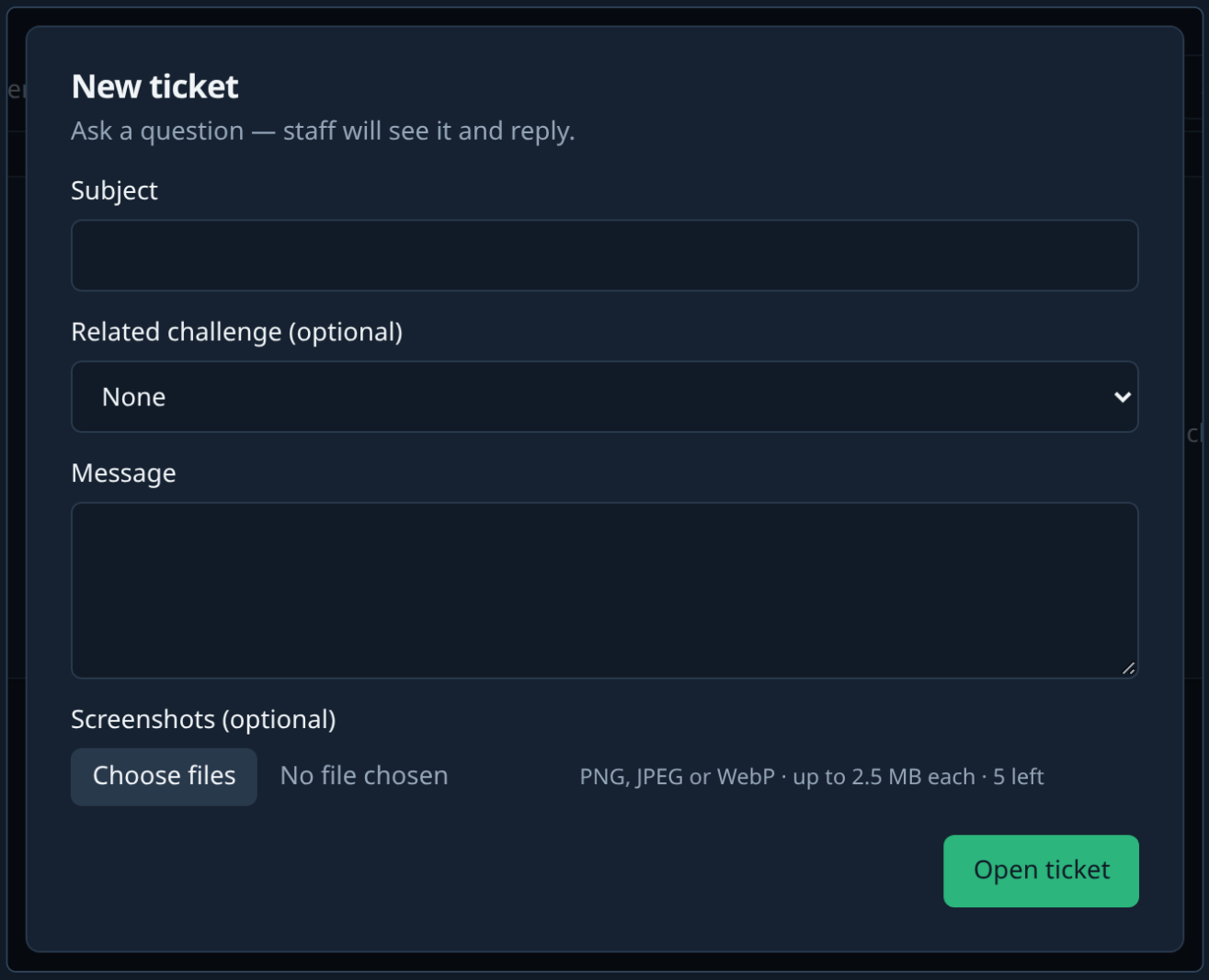
Announcements & notifications

Organisers broadcast **announcements** for anything event-wide. They arrive live as a banner: a routine Announcement shows briefly then tucks into the bell, an Important one stands out, and an Urgent one stays until you dismiss it. Judges' **clarifications** arrive the same way.

The **bell** collects what's addressed to you — ticket replies, announcements and clarifications, certificate releases, organiser alerts — with an unread badge and **Mark all read**. Profile → **Notifications** controls which categories come through (urgent announcements always do), plus **Browser notifications** and a **Sound for support tickets**.

Support tickets

When something's wrong — a target seems down, a sure flag is rejected, you're out of guesses, or you have a rules question — open a ticket from the **Support** page.



New ticket: a subject, the related challenge, your message and optional screenshots. Each ticket is a live conversation — replies appear in real time, and you're notified when the judges answer.

Pick the **Related challenge** rather than naming it in the text, say exactly what you tried, attach **Screenshots** if they help, and keep one issue per ticket. A judge is looking at this ticket means someone has it open right now.

> **ASK EARLY**
>
> Judges would far rather field a quick "is this challenge behaving?" than have you lose an hour to a broken target. You may be the first to notice.

Pages, surveys and the assistant

Organisers often publish extra **pages** — full rules, prizes, venue or sponsor info — listed at the bottom of the sidebar. If **Feedback** appears there, a survey is open for you to **Respond** to. And if the organisers have enabled the **Assistant**, it answers questions about the platform, scoring and your standing; it never reveals flags, how much challenge help it gives is up to the organisers, and staff can review the conversations — it tells you so before you start.

Conduct

The rules you accepted are the contract. The universal baseline: attack only the challenge infrastructure you're pointed at — never the platform or other competitors; don't share flags or solutions outside your team while the event runs (instanced challenges can detect a borrowed flag); report anything that looks like an unintended shortcut. Organisers can see submission patterns — play it straight.

Good luck, and enjoy the event.

CHAPTER 8

FAQ

My flag is right but it was rejected — why?

Leading and trailing whitespace is trimmed, but everything else is graded exactly: the full string, the `flag{...}` wrapper when shown, and case unless that challenge was authored case-insensitive. Paste rather than retype. On an instanced challenge the flag belongs to your running instance — a stopped or relaunched instance has a different one. Still stuck? Open a support ticket with the related challenge selected.

A challenge was worth 500 — why is it 380 now?

That's **dynamic scoring**: the value decays as more people solve it, and every solver holds the current value. On a multiple-choice question it can also be the **wrong-guess penalty** — each wrong answer lowers what the question is worth to you or your team.

I solved something but the scoreboard didn't move.

Near the end of an event the board is often **frozen** — your solve counted the moment you submitted, and standings update at the reveal. Mid-event, remember the board ranks totals: a 100-point solve may not change your rank.

My code was Accepted — why did the points disappear?

Judges can rejudge a problem or decide a verdict by hand, and the **newest verdict counts.** The entry in Your submissions is marked Rejudged or Judge's decision. If you think it's wrong, ask through Support.

Can I use Flagpost on my laptop and phone at once?

Yes — sign in on as many devices as you like. Challenge notes sync live between them; code drafts written in the browser stay on the device you wrote them on.

What if I forget my password mid-event?

Forgot password? on the sign-in page emails a reset link — provided your account has an email address. Add one now, under Profile → Account → Email → **Add email**, before you need it.

I'm out of guesses on a multiple-choice question.

Open a support ticket. Organisers can restore attempts for you or your team — nothing about your history is lost.

I can't join — it says to verify my email.

This site requires a verified email before joining. Profile → Account shows **Verify your email** with **Resend verification email**; click the link in the mail and try again.

How do I get into the next event on this site?

Open the invite link your organisers send, or go to `/lobby` to see public competitions and enter an invite code. Your account carries over.

Who can read my challenge notes?

Your team, and only your team (in individual mode, only you). Write freely.

Can my tools talk to Flagpost directly?

Yes — Profile → **API tokens** → **Create token**: a description, an optional expiry, and your current password. The token is shown **once**; send it as an `Authorization: Bearer` header. Tokens act as you, so treat them like your password and **Revoke** any you stop using.